

TAKE 139

Search Me and Know Me

Psalm 139

A Premarital Diagnostic · Conflict Origins Profile

PREPARED FOR

Sample Reader

May 28, 2026

An assessment created by Dr. Christopher Hilken

Pair Code · EMBER-8244

Your Conflict Origin Story

Every conflict has a story underneath it. Yours is written in four layers — a trigger, a question, a defense, and a breakdown. Here is yours in one sentence.

I am *Sample Reader*, and I grew up in a home that was *a home I'm still making sense of*.

You will find that I'm mainly bothered when I experience *disrespect — being dismissed, overlooked, or treated as though my perspective doesn't count*.

The reason this triggers something deep in me is because a question I'm constantly asking myself is *"Am I competent?"*.

I protect myself from feeling this way most of the time by being *an Architect* — I protect myself by building order. If I can control the environment, the plan, the outcome — my question typically won't get triggered.

But when something gets through my defenses, I cope with that pain by becoming *the Attorney* — I prosecute the case until the verdict is clear — typically in my favor.

Your Four Profile Layers

YOUR PRIMARY TRIGGER

Disrespect-Sensitive

This trigger typically activates around perceived slights to competence, authority, or standing. You don't just feel hurt — you often feel diminished. Minor moments (an eye roll, a dismissive tone, not being consulted on a decision) can land like direct challenges to personhood.

YOUR CORE QUESTION

"Am I competent?"

The Disrespect-Sensitive person is not simply asking "am I smart?" but something more primal: "When you see what I'm actually capable of, will you still respect me?" This is often the performance-orientation question, rooted in conditional acceptance — a home or school environment where love or approval was tied to achievement.

YOUR MECHANISM

An Architect

I protect myself by building order. If I can control the environment, the plan, the outcome — my question typically won't get triggered.

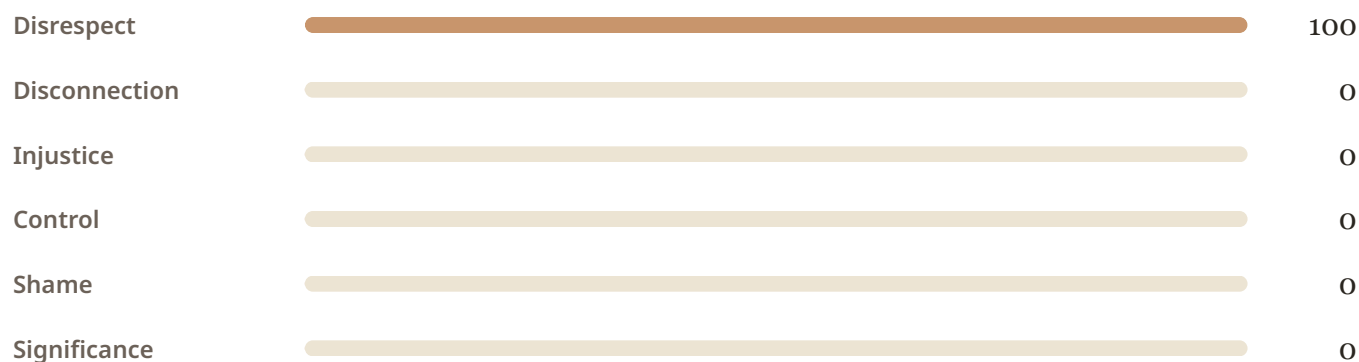
YOUR BREAKDOWN PATTERN

An Attorney

I prosecute the case until the verdict is clear — typically in my favor.

Your Trigger Profile

How sensitive you are to each kind of relational pain, scored out of 100.



Your Trigger · Disrespect-Sensitive

Your most-activated trigger is where conflict will find you first. Here's what it looks like when it fires.

WHAT THIS TRIGGER FEELS LIKE

This trigger typically activates around perceived slights to competence, authority, or standing. You don't just feel hurt — you often feel diminished. Minor moments (an eye roll, a dismissive tone, not being consulted on a decision) can land like direct challenges to personhood.

EVERYDAY MOMENTS THAT ACTIVATE IT

My partner corrects me in public. My idea is dismissed without consideration. I'm left out of a decision that affects me. I'm spoken to with condescension. My contribution isn't acknowledged.

WHAT YOU'LL FEEL WHEN IT FIRES

A hot flash of shame that often converts to indignation. The emotion is experienced as anger, but it typically originates in shame.

Your Core Question · "Am I competent?"

Under every trigger is a question you've been asking yourself since long before this relationship started. For you, it's this one.

WHERE THIS QUESTION TYPICALLY COMES FROM

The Disrespect-Sensitive person is not simply asking "am I smart?" but something more primal: "When you see what I'm actually capable of, will you still respect me?" This is often the performance-orientation question, rooted in conditional acceptance — a home or school environment where love or approval was tied to achievement.

WHY IT SHOWS UP IN CONFLICT

You often carry a permanently active internal ledger: others are scoring you. When justification hasn't been received by the part of the brain that conducts conflict, you typically fight to prove you were right.

TYPICAL PATTERNS IN YOUR LIFE

- You replay conversations after the fact — not because you feel guilty, but because you're rechecking whether you came across well. Did I sound like I knew what I was talking about?
- When someone gives you feedback — even gently — your first instinct is to explain why you did it that way, not to say thank you. You're not defensive on purpose; it just comes out.
- You have strong opinions about the right way to do things, and it bothers you more than it should when people do it the clearly wrong way.
- Being corrected in front of someone else lands very differently than being corrected in private. The information might be the same; the experience is entirely different.
- You've noticed you apologize less quickly than other people — not because you don't care, but because admitting you were wrong feels like losing something.
- Asking for help is genuinely hard. You'd rather figure it out yourself, research it, watch the tutorial, and get it done than let someone see you not know how to do something.
- There's a version of yourself you feel like you have to perform in certain rooms — capable, informed, on top of it. When that version cracks, you feel the crack everywhere.
- You're more comfortable giving advice than receiving it, even from people who love you and know you well.

Your Mechanism · An Architect

Your mechanism is how you organize your inner world day-to-day to keep the question from being answered the wrong way. It's your default operating system.

WHAT AN ARCHITECT LOOKS LIKE

I protect myself by building order. If I can control the environment, the plan, the outcome — my question typically won't get triggered.

TYPICAL PATTERNS IN YOUR LIFE

- Your friends and family tend to come to you when things fall apart. You're the competent one. The reliable one. The "they've got it figured out" one.
- You are almost always the most prepared person in any room. You've thought through the scenarios. You have a plan B.
- When the plan changes unexpectedly, your response is faster and sharper than the situation usually warrants. The disruption lands harder than it should.
- You show love by solving problems. When your partner shares something difficult, your instinct is to help them fix it — not because you don't care about their feelings, but because fixing it is how you care.
- You have high standards — for yourself first, then for others — and you sometimes don't realize how high the bar is for everyone around you until they tell you.
- Rest feels unearned unless the work is done. The work is never entirely done.
- You rarely ask for help. If you do, there's a good chance you've already tried to solve it alone first, and asking feels like the last resort.
- Your systems and routines are not just habits — they're how you stay safe. When they get disrupted, you feel the disruption in your body before you understand it in your mind.

WHAT PEOPLE CLOSE TO YOU OFTEN SAY

The Architect partner is reliable, competent, and responsible — a genuine strength. But they can feel controlling, critical, and emotionally unavailable. Their advice when empathy is needed, and their difficulty receiving help without shame, can make intimacy feel one-directional.

WHERE THIS PATTERN TYPICALLY COMES FROM

No single origin story fits every person — but here are the most common ones we see.

People with this pattern often grew up in a home that felt unpredictable or unstable — financially, emotionally, or in terms of a parent's moods or sobriety. Planning became the way to create safety when the environment wouldn't provide it.

Sometimes this pattern develops in a home that was warm and stable, but where achievement was the primary love language — where performance was consistently celebrated and ordinary moments weren't. The child learns that doing well is what earns belonging.

For some, the Architect pattern comes from having a parent who underfunctioned — through depression, addiction, absence, or immaturity — and the child stepped into a gap that was never theirs to fill. They have been 'holding it together' ever since.

Occasionally this pattern has less to do with wounds and more to do with temperament and giftedness — they are genuinely excellent at systems and planning. But even here, the integration work is learning that their worth is not their competence.

HOW THIS SHOWS UP FOR YOU SPECIFICALLY

What your answers revealed

For you, being an Architect isn't about needing to control other people — it's about what this pattern has been doing for you under the surface. When you take over the planning or start pushing for a solution, the thing you're really protecting is something deeper than the moment itself. The people who know you well would say you're one of the most reliable people they've ever met — and they might also say they sometimes wish you'd put down the clipboard and just be present with them. Here's the thing though: the same quality that makes you exhausting in conflict — the way you can't let something be unresolved, unplanned, or wrong — is also what makes you the person people call when everything falls apart. That's not nothing. But for marriage to work well, you're going to need to develop a second skill: the ability to be incompetent, unfinished, and still in process — and let your partner see that version of you.

Your Breakdown · An Attorney

When your everyday mechanism isn't enough — when something gets through your defenses — this is what comes out.

WHAT AN ATTORNEY LOOKS LIKE

I prosecute the case until the verdict is clear — typically in my favor.

TYPICAL PATTERNS WHEN YOU'RE AT YOUR WORST

- When you're really hurt, you don't just tell someone what they did. You build the case. Evidence, timeline, precedent. The goal shifts from resolution to vindication.
- You remember things. The date. The exact words. What they were wearing. When the argument starts, the archive opens.
- It is very difficult for you to accept "I'm sorry" at face value without a full acknowledgment of what was done wrong. Apology without accountability feels like a door half-opened.
- You can keep an argument going long past the point where the other person has completely lost the thread, because you're not done with the evidence yet.
- In these moments, part of you knows you're pressing too hard. But the need to be vindicated is louder than the knowledge that you're pressing too hard.
- You are not always loud in this mode. Sometimes you're methodical, cold, precise. The quiet version is sometimes more frightening than the loud one.
- After the argument, you feel a complicated mix of relief (the case was made) and shame (that wasn't my best self). The shame doesn't always arrive right away.
- What you want more than winning is for someone to say, genuinely: "You were right. I was wrong. I see it." When that happens, something in you softens immediately.

WHAT YOUR PARTNER WILL SEE

Evidence being cited ("Remember what you did last March?"). Escalating logic. Inability to change the subject or take a break. Feeling cross-examined. The conversation continuing until a confession or surrender is extracted. An inability to accept "I'm sorry" without a full admission of guilt.

HOW THIS SHOWS UP FOR YOU SPECIFICALLY

What your answers revealed

When you go into Attorney mode, it isn't because you love to argue — it's because what this pattern has been doing for you under the surface. What the case is really trying to accomplish is something deeper than the moment itself. Your partner experiences this as being cross-examined and convicted before they've had a chance to respond. What they may not see is that the prosecution is driven by something much more vulnerable than anger: a need to be vindicated, to have the record corrected, to hear someone say 'you were right and you were wronged.' That is a legitimate need. But the courtroom is not the way to get it. Because when you win, the verdict doesn't actually quiet the question underneath. It just buys temporary relief before the next case opens.

The Gospel Truth You Need

Every conflict pattern is ultimately an attempt to answer your core question on your own terms. The gospel answers it on better ones. Here is the truth your profile most needs to hear.

GOSPEL ANCHOR

I am Justified — Christ's perfect righteousness has been credited to my account. The performance ledger is closed.

I am Justified — Christ's perfect righteousness has been credited to my account. There is no verdict left to win. My competence is not on trial in any conflict because my standing before the only Judge who matters is already settled. I can be wrong in an argument without being wronged at the soul level.

2 Corinthians 5:21; Romans 8:1; Galatians 2:20

Reflection Questions

These questions are designed for you and your partner (or a trusted friend or counselor) to walk through together. Don't rush them. The point is not to answer quickly — it's to answer honestly.

1. When have you felt most criticized or undermined by me — and looking back, what do you think the criticism landed on in you? What was the question underneath the sting?
2. Tell me about a time when something went wrong in your life and you had to let someone else handle it. What did that feel like? What would it feel like to let me do that for you sometimes?
3. When I share a problem with you and you go into solution mode — what percentage of the time is that the response I actually needed? What would you need from me so I could get the other response more often?
4. What does rest look like for you? Not vacation, not a productive Saturday — genuine rest with no agenda. When did you last have that? What gets in the way of it in our relationship?
5. If you could be incompetent at one thing in front of me — fully, without managing how I see you — what would it be? What would it take for that to feel safe?

A Prayer For An Architect

Lord, this person right here is holding a lot. You know that. They've been holding it for a long time — probably since before they were old enough to decide to. Someone needed them to be competent and capable and together, and they stepped up, and they've been stepping up ever since. And we want to honor that tonight, right? Because it's real. The faithfulness is real. The reliability is real. The way they show up when things fall apart — that's not nothing.

But God, underneath all the planning and the preparation and the systems is a question they've been asking since they were small: Am I competent enough to be okay? Am I good enough to be kept? And here's the thing — the answer to that question isn't in the next plan or the next project or the next time they hold everything together. The answer has already been given. Christ's competence, credited to them. Christ's righteousness, not theirs, covering the ledger. The verdict is already in.

So would you help them to put down the clipboard, just for a moment? Not forever — they're going to keep being who they are. But help them learn that when they can't hold it together, they are not less. Help them let their partner see the unfinished version. Help them ask for help without feeling like they're losing something. Because they've been holding the world, and you are the one who holds the world — and the difference matters.

In Jesus' name. Amen.

SAVE THIS CODE

Your Pair Code

EMBER – 8 2 4 4

If you're engaged or in a serious relationship, have your partner take the Take 139 assessment and receive their own pair code. When you're both ready, you can use your pair codes to unlock a Couple's Report that shows how your two profiles interact — where you'll clash, where you'll complement, and how to lead each other well. Visit **take139.com** for details.

"Search me, God, and know my heart; test me and know my anxious thoughts. See if there is any offensive way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting." — Psalm 139:23–24

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